

The Louvre

Now a museum housing the world's most famous painting, but also, in its time, a fortress, a palace, and a storehouse of stolen treasure



Located on the banks of the River Seine in Paris, the Louvre attracts over 8 million visitors a year, who come to marvel at its fabulous collection of art and antiquities. It began its existence as a fortress built in the 1190s by Philippe-Auguste, King of France, from 1180 to 1223, and became a royal residence in the 14th century, before François I (r.1515–1547) decided to rebuild it as a magnificent Renaissance palace. François invited Leonardo da Vinci to come to France, and the artist brought the *Mona Lisa* with him.

François' palace was designed by Pierre Lescot (c.1515–1578), with superb bas-reliefs by Jean Goujon (c.1510–1568). Later monarchs left their own mark on the place, the finest addition perhaps being Claude Perrault's elegant, Classical colonnade, commissioned by Louis XIV and built in 1667–1673. His extremely original design was chosen from a competition held in 1664.

A museum of art

French rulers kept their private art collections in the Louvre, but it was only in 1793 that its doors were opened to the public. It was renamed the Musée Napoléon in 1803, when Bonaparte used it to display the artworks he had looted during his campaigns. Most of these were later returned, but the collection and the visiting crowds continue to multiply, so the Louvre itself has been expanded in recent times.

The Louvre Pyramid

In the 1980s, President Mitterrand initiated his “Grand Louvre” project, an ambitious scheme to renovate the museum. Its most spectacular component was the steel and glass Pyramid in the Cour Napoléon. Designed by the Chinese American architect I. M. Pei (1917–2019), it forms the main entrance to the museum.



△ ORNATE FACADE

A detail in the Cour Napoléon shows graceful caryatids (female figures) supporting allegorical figures representing the history of poetry.

▽ LATER ADDITIONS

Originally built as a fortress, the Louvre was enlarged by a succession of French rulers over the centuries. The striking glass pyramid was added to the main courtyard in 1989.

The *Mona Lisa* has her own mailbox at the Louvre to receive the **love letters** sent to her

